



governed in one's mother tongue. But the reluctance to live up to its earlier promise was because the Congress leaders in Delhi half-believed what was being said about India's fragility. In hindsight, we should congratulate ourselves that linguistic states were formed or else we could have headed for a full time civil war as in neighbouring Sri Lanka.

India defied the mythical tales about nation-states from the start. The ambitions to live up to the one national language format were shot down because of strong opposition to Hindi from the South. Hindi was later reinstated, but only as an official language, and that too by a slender majority. But there was practically no opposition to the newly enshrined law that secession would hitherto be treated as a crime against the State (with a capital "S"). When Sardar Patel calmly went about adding to our territorial possessions by integrating swathes of princely India, where was the opposition to it?

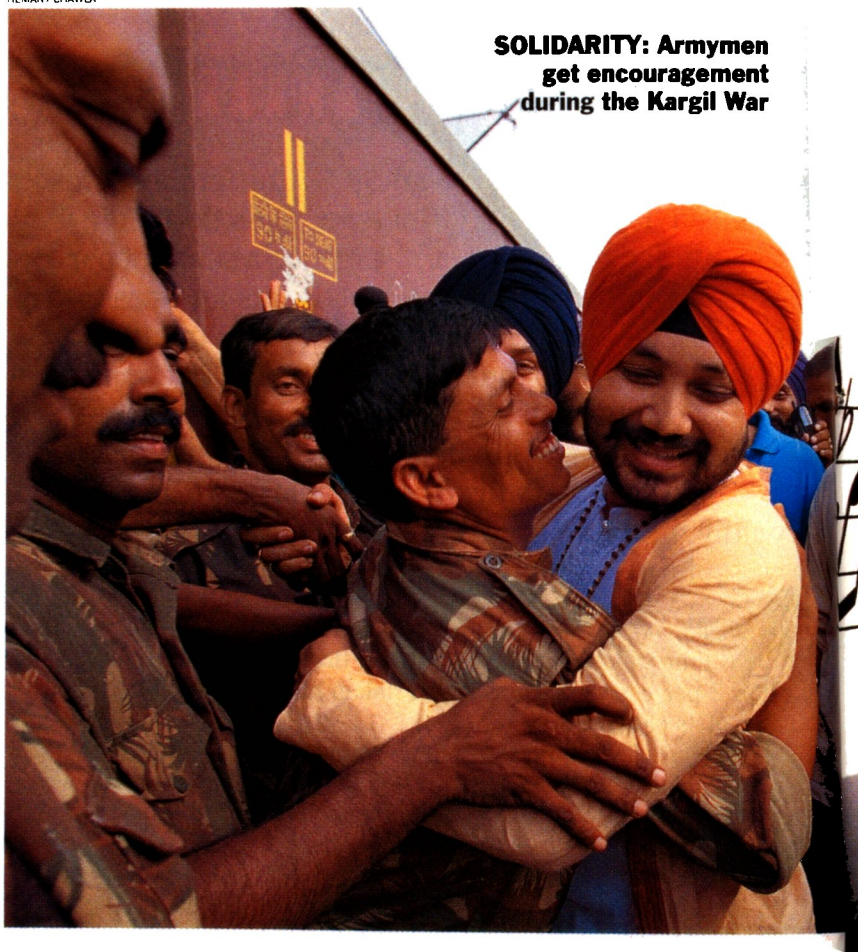
Nehru and others had earlier deposed before a number of British missions, should any section demand secession from the Indian Union later, then that should be respected as a variant of the right to self-determination. But after the reality of Partition, they firmly locked their large, bleeding hearts. From now on the State came down heavily against those who dared disturb "a blade of grass" or a "grain of soil" in our sacred land. And there was no significant voice of demur against such decrees from any quarter.

There is really no yellow brick road to an ideal nation-state. Each sovereign country arrives at this denouement through routes that are peculiar to its history, cultural makeup and, of course, geography. Italy, Spain and France, and indeed, Britain too, did not follow the popular make-believe stories of the perfectionist route to a nation-state. They all differed in their own way, but western commentators have conveniently forgotten their own pasts.

It is indeed impossible to say what keeps a nation-state together. After reviewing piles of literature, Hans Kohn concluded that a nation-state is a nation-state when it sees itself as a nation-state. It is hard to better this pithy aphorism for it puts all analytical attempts to dissect nation-states to rest. Why did Sikhs not support Khalistan? There is no rational answer to this. It is not as if Punjab would economically keel over if it seceded from India. There are dozens of small states that are landlocked and are doing famously. If Kohn were asked, then he would probably say that Sikhs did not want Khalistan because they did not want Khalistan. And that was it.

Ernest Renan once advised students of

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SOLIDARITY: Armymen get encouragement during the Kargil War

Nation-states thrive better on good enemies than on good friends. India's grief is Pakistan, and Pakistan reciprocates this sentiment in turn.

nationalism to stay away from sociologists, and more particularly, ethnographers. This is good counsel because scholars of this ilk are most comfortable in detailing differences and not similarities. As differences sell better and make more interesting copy, these academics revel in measuring distances between people. A nation-state is a putative unity, but how is this achieved? In my view, Renan gave us the only convincing answer to this question. In the ultimate analysis, argued Renan, after all is said and done, it is collective grief that binds a nation-state together like nothing else.

In other words, nation-states thrive better on good enemies than on good friends. America's

